

GRADE 8 · READING INFORMATIONAL TEXT · RI.8.8

Should Cedar Falls Ban Single-Use Plastic Bags?

Delineate the specific claims in an argumentative text, evaluate whether the reasoning connecting evidence to each claim is sound, and recognize when evidence introduced is irrelevant to the claim it is meant to support.

Lesson Map · Passage · Guided · Partner · Independent Practice · Small Group · Answer Key

What You Will Learn Today

Learning Goals

Understand RI.8.8: Delineate the specific claims in an argumentative text, evaluate wheth...

Read an original passage closely

Support every answer with text evidence

Work through guided, partner, and independent practice

How the Lesson Runs

Warm-up and passage

Guided practice together

Partner discussion

Independent + small-group work

Exit ticket and answer key

Unpacking the Standard

A sound argument has claims directly supported by relevant, sufficient evidence. Evidence is irrelevant when it does not actually address the specific claim it appears next to, even if it is a true and interesting fact. At grade 8, evaluating an argument means checking each individual claim against its evidence, not just judging whether the overall conclusion sounds reasonable.

Modeled Example

An article claims, "Plastic bag bans reduce litter," and supports it with, "After a ban, a coastal cleanup organization reported 38 percent fewer plastic bags collected on local beaches." Is this evidence relevant to the claim?

Yes, this evidence is relevant and directly measures the specific claim (litter reduction) using a directly related statistic (fewer bags found in litter cleanups).

The same article also states, "Plastic was first mass-produced in the 1940s, and global plastic production has increased every decade since." Is this evidence relevant to the specific claim that bans reduce local litter?

No, this is irrelevant to that specific claim; while it is a true fact about plastic's history, it says nothing about whether a local bag ban actually reduces local litter, so it does not support or weaken the claim.

Should Cedar Falls Ban Single-Use Plastic Bags?

1. The Cedar Falls city council is considering an ordinance banning single-use plastic bags at grocery and retail stores. I support the ban, based on three specific claims: it will reduce local litter, it will save the city money on storm drain maintenance, and it will not meaningfully increase costs for low-income shoppers.

2. First, the litter claim. Neighboring Fairview banned plastic bags two years ago. A volunteer cleanup organization there reported a 34 percent drop in plastic bags collected during their quarterly creek cleanups, comparing the two years before the ban to the two years after. This is a direct, relevant measurement of the exact outcome the claim predicts: less plastic bag litter after a ban.

3. Second, the storm drain claim. Cedar Falls's own public works department reported spending \$214,000 last year clearing plastic debris, primarily bags, from storm drains after major rain events. Fairview's public works department, after its ban, reported a 40 percent reduction in debris-related drain clogs specifically attributed to plastic bags. Together, these two figures directly support the claim that a ban could meaningfully reduce Cedar Falls's own storm drain costs.

Should Cedar Falls Ban Single-Use Plastic Bags?

4. It is worth noting that plastic bags were introduced to American grocery stores in the 1970s and were marketed at the time as an environmentally friendly alternative to paper bags, since they used less energy to produce. This is a genuinely interesting piece of history, but it has no bearing on whether a ban today would reduce Cedar Falls's current litter or drain-clogging problems, and I include it here only as background, not as evidence for or against the ban.

5. Third, the cost-to-shoppers claim. Fairview's ordinance includes a provision allowing shoppers enrolled in state food assistance programs to receive reusable bags free of charge from participating stores, funded by a small per-transaction fee on non-assistance customers. In the two years since, no formal complaints about the provision have been filed with Fairview's consumer affairs office. This directly addresses whether the specific claim, that costs to low-income shoppers would not meaningfully increase, holds up in a comparable city.

Should Cedar Falls Ban Single-Use Plastic Bags?, continued

6. I want to be clear about the limits of this evidence. Fairview is a similar-sized city with a similar climate and grocery infrastructure to Cedar Falls, which makes its data a reasonable comparison. But it is not Cedar Falls, and local factors — different store layouts, different weather patterns, different shopper habits — could affect how closely Cedar Falls's results would match Fairview's. The evidence supports the three claims; it does not guarantee identical results.

Warm-up · Before You Read

1. What are the three specific claims the author states in paragraph 1?
2. What explicit evidence does paragraph 2 provide for the litter claim, and what specific statistic does it include?

Guided Practice

3. Evaluate whether the evidence in paragraph 2 is relevant to the litter claim. Explain your reasoning.

4. What two specific figures does paragraph 3 provide to support the storm drain claim?

Guided Practice

5. Why does the author present both a Cedar Falls figure and a Fairview figure together in paragraph 3, rather than just one or the other?

6. What piece of evidence does paragraph 4 introduce, and what does the author explicitly say about its relevance?

Partner Discussion

7. Why might the author choose to include the irrelevant historical detail in paragraph 4 at all, if it does not support any claim?

8. What explicit provision from Fairview's ordinance does paragraph 5 describe, related to low-income shoppers?

Partner Discussion

9. What evidence does paragraph 5 provide that this provision has worked as intended, and evaluate whether it is sufficient on its own.

Independent Practice

10. What limitation does the author explicitly acknowledge about using Fairview's data in paragraph 6?

11. How does the author's acknowledgment in paragraph 6 affect the overall soundness of the argument, compared to an argument that made no such acknowledgment?

Independent Practice

12. Which piece of evidence in the entire article is explicitly irrelevant to any of the three claims, and how do you know?

13. Evaluate whether the evidence provided for the storm drain claim (paragraph 3) is sufficient, or whether additional evidence would strengthen it. Explain your reasoning.

Independent Practice

14. A reader claims this article is "biased" because the author openly supports the ban from the first sentence. Using evidence from the text, evaluate whether stating a position upfront makes the argument's reasoning unsound.

15. If a fourth paragraph were added citing "national plastic production has tripled since 1990" as evidence for the storm drain cost claim specifically, would this be relevant or irrelevant? Explain your reasoning using the standard set by paragraph 4.

Small-Group Work

16. What explicit time period does paragraph 2 use for its before-and-after comparison of Fairview's cleanup data?

17. Why is comparing the same two-year window before and after the ban (paragraph 2) a stronger form of evidence than a single after-the-fact number alone would be?

Small-Group Work

18. What explicit dollar figure does paragraph 3 give for Cedar Falls's current storm drain cleaning costs?

19. Delineate the specific claim paragraph 5 is meant to support, and evaluate whether the evidence provided directly measures that claim or only partially addresses it.

Exit Ticket

20. Why does the author's own acknowledgment of uncertainty in paragraph 6 make the argument more sound rather than less sound, even though it admits the evidence is not perfect?

Answer Key (1 of 4)

1. That a ban will reduce local litter, save the city money on storm drain maintenance, and not meaningfully increase costs for low-income shoppers.
2. Fairview's volunteer cleanup organization reported a 34 percent drop in plastic bags collected during quarterly creek cleanups, comparing two years before and after its ban.
3. It is relevant, because it directly measures the exact outcome the claim predicts (less plastic bag litter) using a real before-and-after comparison from a similar situation.
4. Cedar Falls spent \$214,000 last year clearing plastic debris from storm drains, and Fairview reported a 40 percent reduction in plastic-bag-related drain clogs after its ban.
5. Together, the Cedar Falls figure establishes the current cost the city faces, and the Fairview figure shows how much a ban could realistically reduce a similar cost, making the combined evidence more directly relevant and sufficient than either figure alone.

Answer Key (2 of 4)

6. The history of plastic bags being introduced in the 1970s as an "environmentally friendly" alternative to paper; the author explicitly states it "has no bearing" on whether a ban today would help and is included only as background, not as evidence.

7. Including it as clearly labeled background, rather than as supporting evidence, may add context or interest for the reader while the author's explicit disclaimer prevents it from being mistaken for actual support of the argument.

8. Shoppers enrolled in state food assistance programs receive reusable bags free of charge, funded by a small per-transaction fee on other customers.

9. No formal complaints about the provision have been filed with Fairview's consumer affairs office in two years; this is relevant but may not be fully sufficient on its own, since an absence of formal complaints does not necessarily prove there were no informal difficulties, only that none rose to a formal complaint.

10. Fairview is not Cedar Falls, and local factors — different store layouts, weather patterns, and shopper habits — could affect how closely Cedar Falls's results would match Fairview's.

Answer Key (3 of 4)

11. It strengthens the argument's credibility by being honest about the evidence's limits, showing the author supports the claims with real but not absolutely certain evidence, rather than overstating what comparison data from another city can prove.

12. The 1970s history of plastic bags being marketed as environmentally friendly (paragraph 4) is irrelevant, and the author explicitly states this directly in the text rather than leaving it for the reader to infer.

13. The evidence is reasonably sufficient, since it includes both a real local cost figure and a comparable city's actual outcome after a similar policy; it could be strengthened further by data from more than one comparison city, but two directly relevant figures already provide a meaningful basis for the claim.

14. Stating a position upfront does not by itself make reasoning unsound; the article's soundness depends on whether its evidence is relevant and sufficient for each claim, which paragraphs 2, 3, and 5 demonstrate, and the author's explicit acknowledgment of the irrelevant detail (paragraph 4) and the evidence's limitations (paragraph 6) suggest a transparent approach rather than a one-sided, unsound one.

15. It would be irrelevant to the storm drain cost claim specifically, using the same reasoning the author applied to the 1970s history in paragraph 4 — a true, general fact about plastic production nationally says nothing about Cedar Falls's specific storm drain costs or how a local ban would affect them.

Answer Key (4 of 4)

16. Two years before the ban compared to two years after the ban.

17. A before-and-after comparison over the same length of time helps isolate the effect of the ban itself, making it more likely the 34 percent drop is connected to the policy rather than to some unrelated yearly fluctuation.

18. \$214,000 spent last year clearing plastic debris, primarily bags, from storm drains after major rain events.

19. The claim is that the ban will not meaningfully increase costs for low-income shoppers; the evidence (no formal complaints in two years) partially addresses this by suggesting no major problems arose, but does not directly measure actual costs shoppers may have absorbed informally, so it only partially, not fully, measures the specific claim.

20. Sound reasoning includes recognizing the actual limits of one's evidence rather than overstating it; by honestly noting that Fairview's results may not perfectly predict Cedar Falls's results, the author avoids an overreaching claim the evidence cannot fully support, which is a mark of careful, sound reasoning rather than weak reasoning.

Exit Ticket

Answer on a sticky note

Answer the exit-ticket question from today's lesson.

Cite at least one piece of evidence from the passage.

Remember

Name your claim or answer

Quote or cite the evidence

Explain how it supports your answer